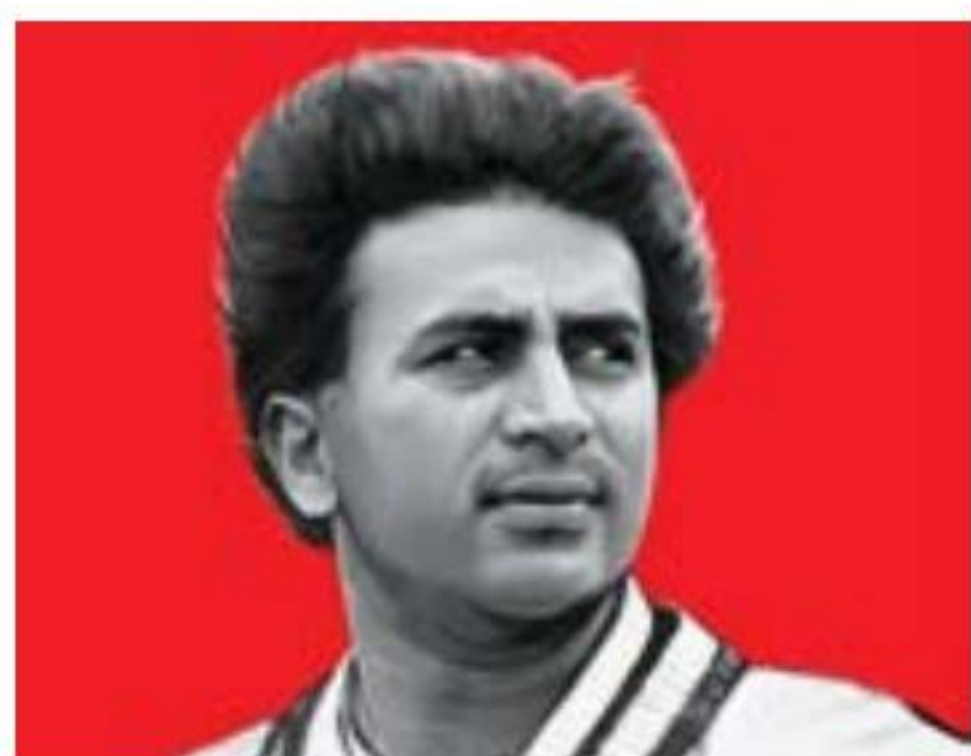




ON THE WRITE LINE

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WEST INDIES HAS TALENT BUT APPLICATION AND HARD WORK THAT TEST CRICKET DEMANDS SEEM JUST A TAD TOO MUCH FOR THEM

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The ease with which India won the first Test match in Ahmedabad was no doubt wonderful to watch for Indian cricket fans, but at the same time, it was saddening to see the depths to which the West Indies, a once invincible team, had fallen.

There is not a cricket lover in the world who isn't disappointed by the performances of the West Indies Test teams over the last couple of decades or so. Go around the cricketing world, and even those former players who suffered at the hands of the great West Indies teams of the 1960s to early 2000s feel frustrated at the performances.

The West Indies players, even today, are the most loved and popular players on the cricketing circuit because of the flair they bring to the game and the zing they get with their teams off the field. Make no mistake, they have talent, but it seems like the application and hard work required in Test matches are just a tad too much for them. Is it simply a question of a format where there is less money but more effort compared to the white-ball formats, especially the T20 version, where there is more

money but less effort?

To see their new-ball attack in the first Test in Ahmedabad was a shock to those who have grown up seeing the ball whistle past the batters' noses at least two or three times in an over. In Ahmedabad, apart from Jayden Seales, the other two were simply trundlers, who looked more like net bowlers than international ones. **No disrespect intended to them, but to see the first bouncer being bowled after half a dozen overs had been bowled made one ask, 'Is this really the West Indies pace attack?'** Yes, bowling bouncers is a big effort, and on a hot day, it can take a lot out of a bowler, but it is a surprise weapon to stop the batter from moving on to the front foot regularly. India's batters were not only on the front foot every ball but were also disdainfully walking down the pitch to the so-called quicks as if they were spinners. As said earlier, Test matches are a lot of hard work with not much reward, so why give it the extra effort?

Even in the batting, there was little effort to buckle down and fight it out. Only Justin Greaves, to some extent in both innings, and Alick Athanaze in the second, looked like they